

Little Bluestem

Schizachyrium scoparium

Beard Grass



QUALITIES

The signature native warm-season grass of dry prairies and oak savannas, growing 2 to 3 feet tall in a fountain-shaped clump. Blue-green summer foliage shifts in autumn to the famous copper-and-mahogany tones that define Minnesota prairie color through October. Feathery silver seedheads catch backlighting from late summer through winter — among the best sources of structural light in any native garden.

CARE

Full sun, well-drained soil; sand to loam. Drought-tolerant once established. Deer- and rabbit-resistant. Hardy to USDA Zone 3. Plant from 1-gallon container 18 to 24 inches apart for a meadow matrix; closer for a tighter ribbon. Leave standing through winter — the structure is the point. Cut to 6 inches in late February or March before new growth.

HISTORY

Little bluestem co-dominated the tallgrass prairie with Big Bluestem (*Andropogon gerardii*) — together they formed the iconic 6-foot grass sea of pre-settlement Minnesota. The deep root systems (down to 6 feet) built the legendary prairie soils that drew settlers and destroyed the prairies in equal measure. Today, less than 2% of Minnesota's tallgrass prairie remains. Each residential planting of little bluestem is a small act of restoration.

REASON TO BE

Little bluestem is the structural connective tissue of a savanna-style residential bed. Planted in repeated drifts, it weaves between forb mass and unifies the composition. It provides cover for ground-nesting native bees and small birds; its seedheads feed sparrows in winter. It hosts the larvae of many native butterflies and skippers. And in November when every forb has gone brown, the copper bluestem still glows like an ember through the snow.